THE BURGESS PERSIAN LETTERS

Edited by BENJAMIN SCHWARTZ

PART VI

[EDWARD BURGESS TO GEORGE BURGESS] *Tabreez, July 3, 1845*

When you can find a few spare minutes to write to me I shall be glad to hear how you are employed. I continue to write you every three months. And I trust this will find you safely returned from America. The last news we had from England was Sir Rt Peel declaration about Oregon. I sincerely trust we shall have no war, and the missionaries here who are to a man conservatives (whigs I think the Americans call them) and anti slavery men, think there will be none because they say that altho Polk was elected by the low party theirs is still strong enough to prevent mischief. I hope so.

I have been pruning a vine this morning; vines in this country are pruned twice a year, first in March, before they shoot, and again now. For many years I always had a gardener to prune the vine opposite my windows and I was surprised that it grew no bigger, at last I found that they cut it as they cut the vines in their vineyards, so as to bear much fruit and grow no bigger, last year I gave it the second pruning myself, and this year both. And it has already increased one third and I hope this year to train it from end to end of the court-yard, about twenty yards, it is already more than half across. Notwithstanding the tremendous cutting I gave it in the spring it has on it as fine a crop of grapes as I recollect to have seen; I cut it so as to send all the force of the sap into the outside branches on both sides and I cut away much of the sound bearing wood, and did not expect this year that it would have any fruit on it, or at least very little. I believe vines might be cultivated with success in England. The intense cold of last winter some forty degrees more intense than it was with you has not injured my vine at all. It is scarcely necessary to remind you that vines in this country are unprotected in the winter from the cold except the protection they get from a covering of snow.

A Mr Mann, formerly a clerk in the foreign office, has arrived here lately from England and goes on to take his place as attaché to the mission at Tehran; he is quite a young man, intelligent and agreeable, and I wish he was going to stay here. I do not think he will remain long at Tehran, he will find it so dull, though according to all accounts, better now than last year, as Col Farrant and Dr Bell, lately joined, and they talk, the others are as silent as trappist monks. Some years ago when the elder brother of this Dr Bell was there, he being a jolly fellow disliked eating every day in silence, and they say, for mind I am not answerable for the truth of the story, that he would at dinner some times talk

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